investors and thus deterred investment, and financial woes among international leaders in the civilian nuclear industry. However, the indirect benefits were much more evident. India's nuclear status ceased to become an irritant in its relations with the United States and its European and Japanese allies. This allowed India's relations with these powers to assume a truly strategic dimension. Already, from 2005 onwards, India's defence cooperation with the United States had steadily improved. India acquired its first major American defence platforms in several generations, including heavy lift transport aircraft, maritime surveillance planes, helicopters, and artillery. Military exercises also increased in regularity and sophistication, particularly in the maritime realm. In 2007, India, the United States, Japan, Australia, and Singapore took part in a massive naval exercise (called Malabar) in the Bay of Bengal. This corresponded with a working level meeting that year between the foreign ministries of India, the United States, Japan, and Australia, which came to be known as the Quad. [42]

Closing Chapters: India's Neighbourhood, 2005–2008

One other outcome of the major developments between 1998 and 2008—the Kargil War, normalized economic relations with China, the civilian nuclear agreement with the United States, and the strong performance of the Indian economy—was the 'de-hyphenation' of India and Pakistan. [43] For much of independent India's history, the two countries were closely associated with each other in the minds of the international community. India's foreign relations—as with West Asia—were often guided by calculations of competing for influence with Pakistan. Policymakers in Washington, London, Moscow, Beijing, and other capitals had traditionally been sensitive of needs to 'balance' relations between New Delhi and Islamabad. But it was over the course of this period from the late-1990s to early-2000s that India managed to a large extent to dilute that association and be treated on its own merits. The rising profile of the Indian economy was the primary factor, but India's behaviour during crises with Pakistan,